You can buy ready-diced mixed game which includes furred game and pigeon, or use diced venison, rabbit, or hare. Aged beef is another option.

puff-crusted game soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 1 HR 20 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS AT THE END OF STEP 2

1–2 tbsp butter
6oz (175g) diced game meat, thawed if frozen, cut into small pieces
1 red onion, chopped
2 tbsp plain flour
1 quart (1 liter) beef stock
1 tbsp redcurrant jelly
3 button mushrooms, halved and sliced
1 tbsp chopped fresh sage
4 tbsp ruby port
salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 sheet ready-rolled puff pastry, thawed if frozen
1 egg, beaten

1 Melt the butter in a saucepan and cook the meat and onion for 5 minutes, stirring, until browned.

2 Blend in the flour and cook for 1 minute. Remove from the heat, gradually stir in the stock, add the jelly, and bring to a boil, stirring. Add the mushrooms, sage, port, and some seasoning. Bring back to a boil, reduce the heat, cover, and simmer very gently for 1 hour, stirring from time to time until rich and really tender. Taste and adjust the seasoning if necessary.

3 Meanwhile, preheat the oven to 425°F (220°C). Cut four circles from the pastry slightly larger than deep oven-proof soup cups and brush with beaten egg. Stand the soup cups on a baking sheet. Brush the edges with beaten egg. Ladle in the soup. Top with the circles of pastry, pressing down lightly with a fork around the edge to secure. Make a small slit in the top of each pie lid with a sharp knife to allow the steam to escape. Bake in the oven for about 15 minutes or until puffy, crisp, and golden brown. Allow to cool for 3–5 minutes before serving.